Coding for Vibe Coders, Non-Coders and Everyone Else, WI26

🦜 What Is CODESHIP? What Is This Course?

This basic seminar is part of CODESHIP, a supportive community for critical–creative coding that emphasizes co-learning, co-teaching, tinkering, and works in progress. With a welcoming, non-intimidating approach, the course aims to help you gain comfort with the key concepts of computational thinking and to question those concepts through intersectional lenses. You can launch (or troubleshoot) a code-related dream project, ask 'silly' questions and explore new programming skills suited to your artistic practice.

Together we will explore foundational techniques across programming languages, gaining practice with Python and/or Javascript, and you will have the chance to experiment with these and other tools that support your ideas. We will explore how (when, whether) to use AI in your coding practice, as well as better practices of digital care at this pivotal moment of high-risk tech. We will engage the historical, sociotechnical, and material stakes of computation as we create critical-creative projects that treat code as an artistic material and critical aesthetic form. We will test the limits of our own expectations for what code should be and should do.

Who

Prof. Dr. Sarah Ciston (they/them), sarah dot ciston at khm dot de, Sprechstunden: Tues & Thur 14.00–15.50. Make an appointment: https://tinyurl.com/chatwsarah

miguel marañas, Student Assistant, miguel dot rodriguez-bermudez at khm dot de

🏴‍☠️ Where & When

Weekly Seminar Schedule*

Seminars every Thursday 10.00-13.00 CET, 22 Oct–21 Jan @ CODESHIP KHM

* Please keep an eye on the schedule. Assignments and dates will change in order to adapt to the needs of the seminar and students' progress

** See Readings to access the Course Reader and the P4E textbook.

SEMINAR DATE	TOPICS	MATERIALS DUE	WORKSHOPEE
22 Oct	Project Mapping & Pseudocoding	-	-
29 Oct	Variables, Loops & Conditions	Reader: Keeling, Baraka, Blackwell; Python for Everybody (P4E) Chs 1,2,3	
TUE 03 Nov, 11.00 Meet at Computer Lab, Aula Building NOT 05 Nov	Skills & Tools: Critical AI Use	Reader: Ciston et al; P4E Chs 4,5,6,7 *by next week*	-

SEMINAR DATE	TOPICS	MATERIALS DUE	WORKSHOPEE
12 Nov	Strings & Source(ry)	Reader: Chun, Yang, also Yang (2022), Yang 2023a, Yang (2023b); P4E Chs 4,5,6,7	
WED 18 Nov, 14:00-16:00 & Thu 19 Nov	Care & Risk (special seminars for *Wissenschaft gegen Faschismus* Aktionswoche, in collaboration with Dr. Katrin Kämpf's seminar)	Reader: Morrison & Britton; P4E Chs 8,9,10,11 *by next week*	
26 Nov	Materials & (Data)Structures	Course Check-In; Reader: Nakamura; P4E Chs 8,9,10,11	
03 Dec	Databases & Power	Reader: Crawford & Joler, calculatingempires.com, Couldry & Mejias; P4E Chs 12–16 as relevant	
10 Dec	*Open Co-Lab Co-Working*	**Schedule a Project Sprechstunde**	-
17 Dec	Logics & Ideologies	Reader: Steyerl, Amoore	
07 Jan	Project dev & feedback sessions	(TBD based on student interests)	
14 Jan	Project dev & feedback sessions	(TBD based on student interests)	
21 Jan	**Demo Day**: poster presentations & project demos	Final projects & research posters due	-

Special Events Schedule

CODESHIP EVENT	DETAILS
Spooky Screening: *A Girl Walks Home Alone at Night*	Fri 30 Oct, 19-21h
Tech Screening: *Ghost in the Machine* Documentary hosted by KISD	Tue 10 Nov, 17:30, KISD
Tokens Workshop with Ting (email Sarah if interested)	Fri 13 Nov, 13.00-16.00

CODESHIP EVENT	DETAILS
🦜 Stochastic Parrots Social Club	Tue 24 Nov, Time TBD

Why

- because code should not be left to the white tech broligarchy
- because artistic research and experimentation can make tangible shifts in the places most impacted by emerging tech
- because coding is fun and shouldn't be so hidden away with obtuse language

These are some of my (Sarah's) reasons, what are yours?

Goals & Outcomes

You'll understand how artists, engineers, makers, and scholars can embrace coding with a critical eye toward ethics and a creative glint that can help imagine more equitable futures.

You'll gain comfort exploring data and coding, building on any existing skills with new perspectives both technical and critical.

You'll build upon your portfolio of individual and collaborative code projects, as well as your community of practice among critical-creative coders.

Outcomes depend on your own goals and are measured on an individual basis in consultation with the instructor. Start by setting your own goal for what you'd like to get out of the semester and how you'd like to contribute to any group goals. Check in midway and toward the end of the term to see how your goals may have changed after working on your project.

How

Prerequisites

None! No particular experience is required. Any kind of field or background is helpful to get started. Don't worry, no matter your existing level of comfort with code, even if it's none, we meet each other where we are. You don’t have to install or buy anything in advance either; we’ll handle that together. It's great if you have in mind a project or a skill you want to work on. If not, you might start from asking, *"What do I wish were in the world, and why?"*

Seminar Format

Rather than a top-down lecture format, this seminar is organized from the bottom up. It aims for students to direct their own course of learning with the instructor as coach or guide. The purpose of this approach is to provide meta-skills like independent investigation, research intuition, and broader skill-building, as well as a supportive environment for all types of learners to explore and take creative risks.

1. **Opening Check-Ins**: Two minutes per person. *What are you working on, wondering, worrying about, or wowed by?*
2. **Code Workshop**: Group engagement with sample or student code to analyze and offer feedback. Includes review of programming concepts.

3. **Discussion**: Group engagement with the weekly reading or other shared material. Includes review of computing concepts.
4. **Co-working, Troubleshooting, Short Lessons**: Self-directed, based on what came up during check-ins, workshop, and discussion.
5. **Closing Check-In**: Wrap up and set plans for next meeting.

CODE WORKSHOPS

You'll sign up for us to workshop your project on a particular day. Be ready to bring in some code, no matter what stage your project is in.

Each session we will close-read someone's code, troubleshoot any issues, support the project's development, talk through the ideas critically and creatively, but also the code itself. Talk about why something works or how it might work differently. Talk about the style, how it's organized, where it's going next, what tools it uses, and why. Maybe we use AI tools to support or not. We put our heads together as a group with different levels of experience and talk through its sociocultural, aesthetic and technical aspects.

Rather than teach programming in a traditional, linear fashion (you'll have access to that in the sources provided), we will move conceptually based on what is relevant for each project, explaining code skills as we go.

READINGS & DISCUSSIONS

Our seminar is oriented around projects and research you develop, built upon the readings and media we engage with and the conversations we have about them and your own practice. These readings are required and will support your projects and your course progress.

Our primary texts include a READER that you can print or use as a PDF, which combines many selections around the course topics, as well as an introductory text for programming in Python. It also comes as a set of slides or videos if you prefer, and it is translated into multiple languages. If your project is better suited to another programming language, such as Javascript, or if you prefer learning by video or online exercises, we can support your progress in this instead. Please consult with us for equivalent chapters for your assignments.

Requirements for Schein/Certificate:

Please complete all three of the following before requesting the KHM Schein for this seminar:

1. Office Hours (Sprechstunde), one or more visits with Sarah about your course project
2. Successful Research Poster (or other discussed format, e.g. term paper) presented on Demo Day
3. Successful Project (or other discussed format, e.g. curation or collaboration) presented on Demo Day

Lab Guide & Community Commitments

We ask you to read and follow all Community Commitments and the CODESHIP Lab Navigation Guide while you are at the Lab and participating in the seminar. KHM House Rules also apply.